

CHILLISOURCE GAME ENGINE PARTICLE STUDY

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ChilliSource Game Engine Particle Study

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This is the short summary of why this thesis is awesome and *YOU* really want to read it!

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

Thanks guys ...

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CHAPTER 1 INTRODUCTION

1.1 Thesis Organization

The rest of this thesis is organized as follows:

- **Chapter 2** Review of particle systems and the ChilliSource game engine
- **Chapter 3** Overview of the automated pong game that was created to facilitate case studies
- **Chapter 4** Discussion of the two case studies performed to explore contention in large data structures
- **Chapter 5** Discussion of three interesting aspects of the ChilliSource particle effect component

CHAPTER 2 BACKGROUND

2.1 Particle Systems

2.1.1 Overview

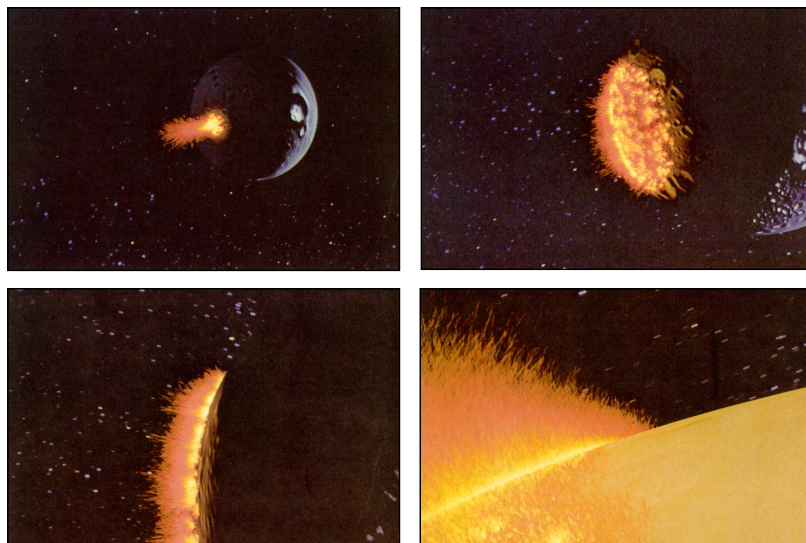


Figure 2.1: The particle effect created by William T. Reeves from the film *Star Trek II: The Wrath of Khan*

Visual representation of "fuzzy objects", or objects that do not have well-defined surfaces, in computer graphics is generally considered a difficult task due to the non-deterministic changes in the fuzzy object's shape and form. When working on the film *Star Trek II: The Wrath of Khan*, a researcher at Lucasfilm Ltd., William T. Reeves, developed what he called a **particle system**, which is "... a collection of many minute particles that together represent a fuzzy object. Over a period of time, particles are generated into a system, move and change from within the system, and die from the system." [1] Although the concept of modeling these objects as a collection of particles was not novel, Reeves' basic framework for particle systems is still widely used today to

create complex visual effects in video games and films.

Fuzzy objects like sparks, clouds, stars, water, and crowds of people can be easily translated and modeled as a particle system, but particle systems can also be used to model objects that contain numerous strands like hair and grass. These objects can be represented by rendering every strand as the entire lifetime of a particle in the system and is then treated as a single strand. The particles in a system that have a distributed lifetime (e.g. sparks) are thought of as **animated** and particles that are rendered all at once (e.g. hair) are thought of as **static**.

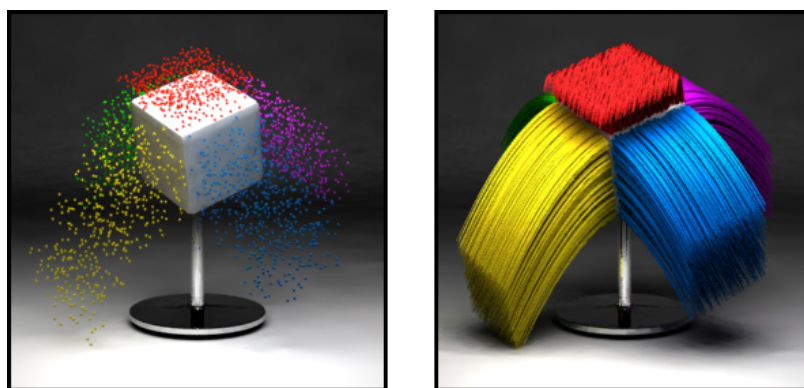


Figure 2.2: Left: A cube emitting a stream of 1000 animated particles from 5 of its 6 faces. Right: A cube emitting a stream of 1000 static particles, or strands, from 5 of its 6 faces

2.1.2 Particle Model

2.1.2.1 Life Cycle

A particle system has 4 main events that defines its life cycle:

1. Emission (or Generation, according to Reeves)
2. Update
3. Render
4. Death (or Extinction, according to Reeves)

The *Emission* event is the initial process in which particles are generated with their initial values. Often a "generation shape"[1] is used during the emission phase that defines the two or three dimensional space that the particles can originate, or emit, from. Emission can be increased or decreased in frequency using the **emission rate**, and the number of particles that enter the particle system each emission can also be changed using the **particles per emission** variable. After emission,

particles in the particle system undergo the *Update* and *Render* events. These events are repeated in perpetuum until the particle dies, or undergoes the extinction phase. The update phase involves iterating over all particles throughout the system and updating their attributes (e.g. position, velocity, etc.). The render phase, on the other hand, is the phase in which all of the particles are actually drawn to the screen.

2.1.2.2 Particle Attributes

As mentioned above, each individual particle in a particle system will have attributes that change over time. Although every particle system is different, the following is what Reeves considered to be the core attributes of a particle:

- Position
- Velocity
- Size
- Color
- Transparency
- Shape
- Lifetime

A particle has a position in two or three dimensional space, and its initial position is determined by the emission process. Other attributes that may also change over time include its speed, direction, size, color, and transparency. Its lifetime, however, is pre-determined at emission, and it is the attribute that dictates how long the particle "lives", or remains on the screen. In order to decrease uniformity and increase realism, all of these values can vary across the particles in the system. For example, the particles in a given particle system could have a varying lifetime of 5 to 10 seconds so that the particles that shared an emission would not all die simultaneously.

2.1.2.3 Hierarchy

It is often convenient to design a particle system such that it is made up of a hierarchy of child particle systems. This hierarchy "can be used to exert global control on a complicated fuzzy object that is composed of many particle systems." [1] In other words, a fuzzy object could easily be transformed in overall shape, size, color, etc. by sweeping through the descendant particle systems. It also allows the grouping together of particle systems that have different types of particles. For example, a campfire fuzzy object would need smoke, sparks, and the flame itself. All of these

components would have distinct particle definitions and would be separate particle systems. A particle system hierarchy, in this case, would allow the smoke, sparks, and flame particle systems to be bundled together as a single fuzzy object.

2.2 The ChilliSource Game Engine

2.2.1 Overview

Chosen for its open source and well-thought out architecture, ChilliSource is the game engine that was used in our study of particle systems. ChilliSource is a free, open source game engine created by ChilliWorks which is a group that is part of United Kingdom's Tag Games. It allows developers to create 2D and 3D content for iOS, Android, Kindle, and Windows operating systems in C++ 11. Some of its key features include networking, shader support, responsive (i.e. adaptive to different resolutions) graphical user interfaces, modular and extensible lighting and shadows, skinned animation, Facebook connect integration, consistent API, and automatic builds of iOS/Android/Kindle applications. [2]

2.2.2 Architecture

The structure of a ChilliSource application is primarily composition based in that it relies on a hierarchy of modules to define its functionality. The main types of modules that comprise the application are *States*, *Systems*, *Entities* and *Components*. Figure 2.3 demonstrates the architecture of a ChilliSource application using these basic modules.

The *Application* instance initializes and manages *Application Systems*, which are modules that describe functionality used across the entire application. A non-exhaustive list of some application systems include the *Task Manager*, *Texture Provider*, *Render System*, and the *State Manager*. The *State Manager*, as shown in Figure 2.3, manages a stack of *States* and ensures that the state on top of the stack is active.

States can be thought of as different parts of the application such as a main menu, inventory, settings menu, pause screen, and the game scene itself. *States*, like the *Application*, initialize and manage *State Systems*. *State Systems* are similar to *Application Systems* except they describe functionality that only pertains to a single state and its lifetime is limited to that state. An important state system, the *Scene*, manage *Entities* that form that scene. The base *State* also creates and

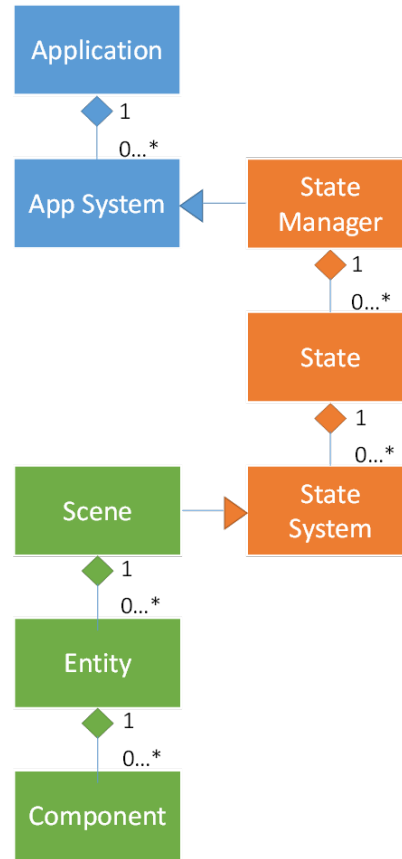


Figure 2.3: The basic structure of a ChilliSource application

manages the *Canvas*, *Gesture*, and *"User"* state systems. The *Canvas* renders the user interface, the *Gesture* state system helps receive input events like pinching or tapping, and *"User"* state systems are custom modules built by the developer to describe functionality for the state.

Entities are essentially objects within the game that are defined by (a) a transform describing their rotation, size, and position and (b) *Components*, which are modules that describe the entity's functionality. *Entities* can also contain a hierarchy of entities in which, much like in particle systems, their transforms and life cycle events are linked by the hierarchy. Some examples of *Components* are AI Controllers, Health, Damage, and Physics. It is easy to see the potential of reuse with this design since one could, for example, attach the same Health Component to enemy and player *Entities* if you wished for both of them to keep track of their health without writing redundant code.

2.2.3 Life Cycle

Life cycle events in a ChilliSource application all originate from the *Application* instance. The main life cycle events are:

1. Init
 - This initializes the application and begins the **Update** event.
2. Update
 - This updates the application, its systems, and the state manager's states.
3. Render
 - This renders objects and user interface elements to the screen and is the main draw loop of the application.
4. Suspend
 - This will notify active state(s) to pause and it will suspend all systems in reverse order.
5. Resume
 - This resumes the application from a suspended state.
6. Background
 - This occurs when the application is not in view any longer.
7. Foreground
 - This occurs when the application is in view again.
8. Destroy
 - This cleans up the application and releases all systems in reverse order.

All of these events are kicked off from the *Application* instance. The flow of events look something like *Application* → *Application Systems (State Manager)* → *States* → *State Systems (Scene)* → *Entities* → *Components*. Figure 2.4 shows what this flow looks like for the **Update** life cycle event using psuedocode.

Although these are the main events that are automatically pushed by the application, the game developer can create custom events that can be subscribed to by entities, components, and systems. An *Event* can open, close, and notify *Connections*, where a *Connection* allows its user to listen for *Events*. Some examples of custom events are Entity Collision, Player Death, Cut Scene Trigger, Game Lost, and Game Won.

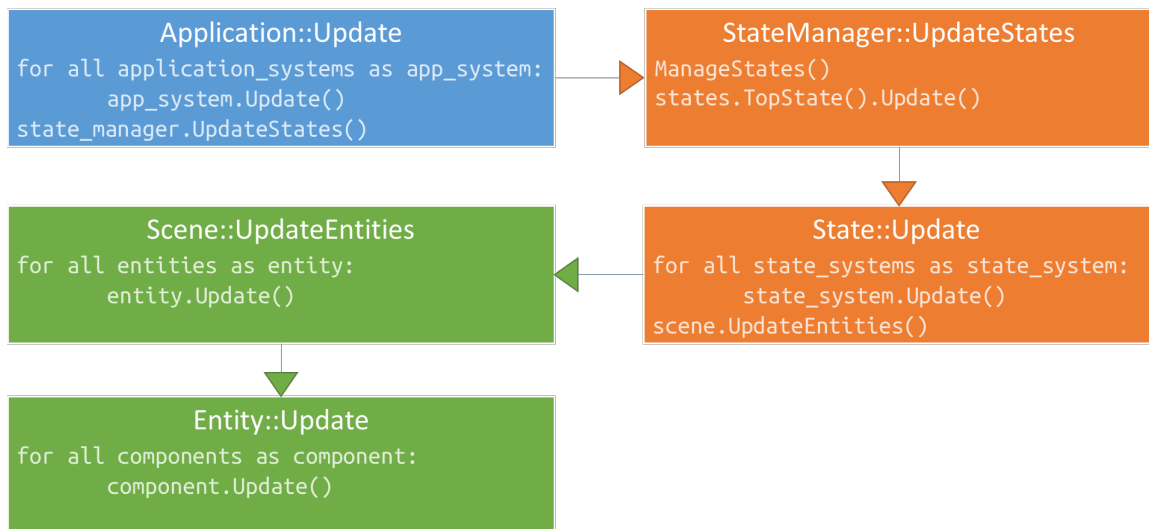


Figure 2.4: An example of the **Update** life cycle event being perpetuated from the *Application* all the way down to a *Component*

2.3 ChilliSource Particle Effect Components

2.3.1 Overview

A special type of component in ChilliSource is the *Particle Effect Component*. It inherits from the *Render Component* class, which is, as it sounds, a component that is rendered to the screen. *Render Components* have methods for Visibility, Culling, Casting Shadows, Retrieval of its Transformation Matrix, and Retrieval of its Sort Predicates. They also have virtual methods that child classes can define for Materials, Transparency, Rendering, and Bounding Boxes.

2.3.2 Usage

2.3.3 Architecture

2.3.4 Attributes

2.3.5 Life Cycle

2.3.5.1 Overview

2.3.5.2 Update Event

2.3.5.3 Render Event

CHAPTER 3 THE CHILLISOURCE AUTOMATED PONG GAME

**CHAPTER 4 CHILLISOURCE PARTICLE EFFECT COMPONENT
CASE STUDIES**

CHAPTER 5 CHILLISOURCE PARTICLE EFFECT COMPONENT OBSERVATIONS

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